

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Audience: Software engineering leads and technology strategists | Tone: Data-forward, analytical

The TIOBE index tracks programming language popularity using search engine data. March 2026 ratings are aggregated from Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20 other sources. The index reflects language mindshare and discoverability, not runtime performance. This report moves from current rankings to biggest movers, long-term historical context, and strategic implications.

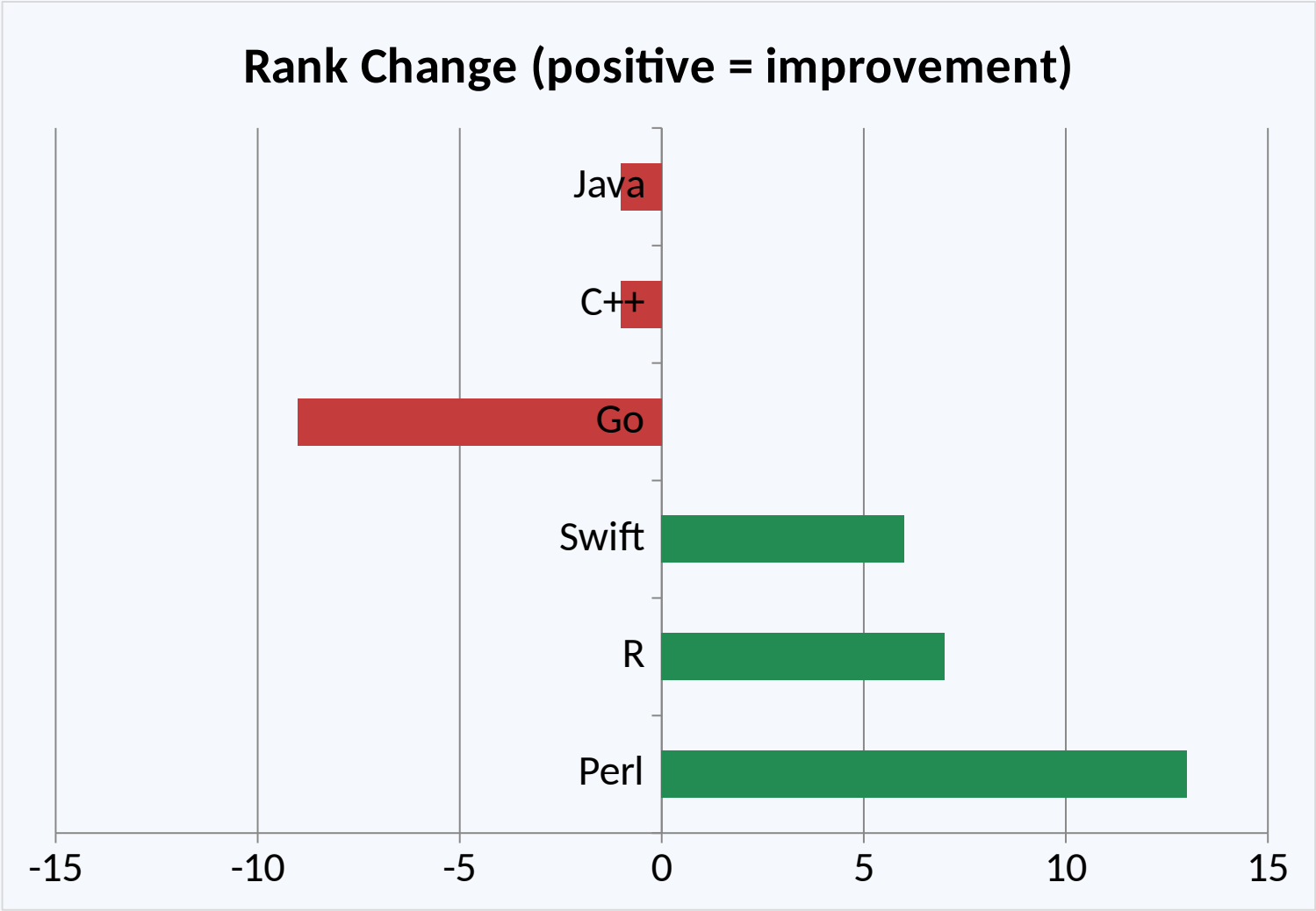
March 2026
Python: 21.25%
Top 4 total: 48.97%

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

2026 Rank	Language	2025 Rank	Mar 2026 Rating %	YoY Change (pts)
1	Python	3	21.25	-2.59
2	C	4	11.34	+2.02
3	C++	2	9.94	+0.19
4	Java	3	9.65	-0.80
5	C#	5	4.96	-0.46
6	JavaScript	6	3.38	-0.08
7	Go	7	2.76	-1.49
8	Visual Basic	8	2.62	-0.54
9	R	16	2.34	+0.94
10	SQL	9	1.90	-0.12
11	Perl	24	1.77	+1.05
12	Fortran	12	1.49	+0.02
13	Delphi/Object Pascal	10	1.37	-0.58
14	Rust	17	1.22	+0.09
15	MATLAB	18	1.21	+0.10
16	Ada	14	1.19	-0.13
17	Scratch	15	1.13	-0.13
18	PHP	11	1.12	-0.65
19	Assembly language	19	1.09	-0.02
20	Swift	26	0.98	+0.44

Source: TIOBE Index March 2026 (top 20 table).

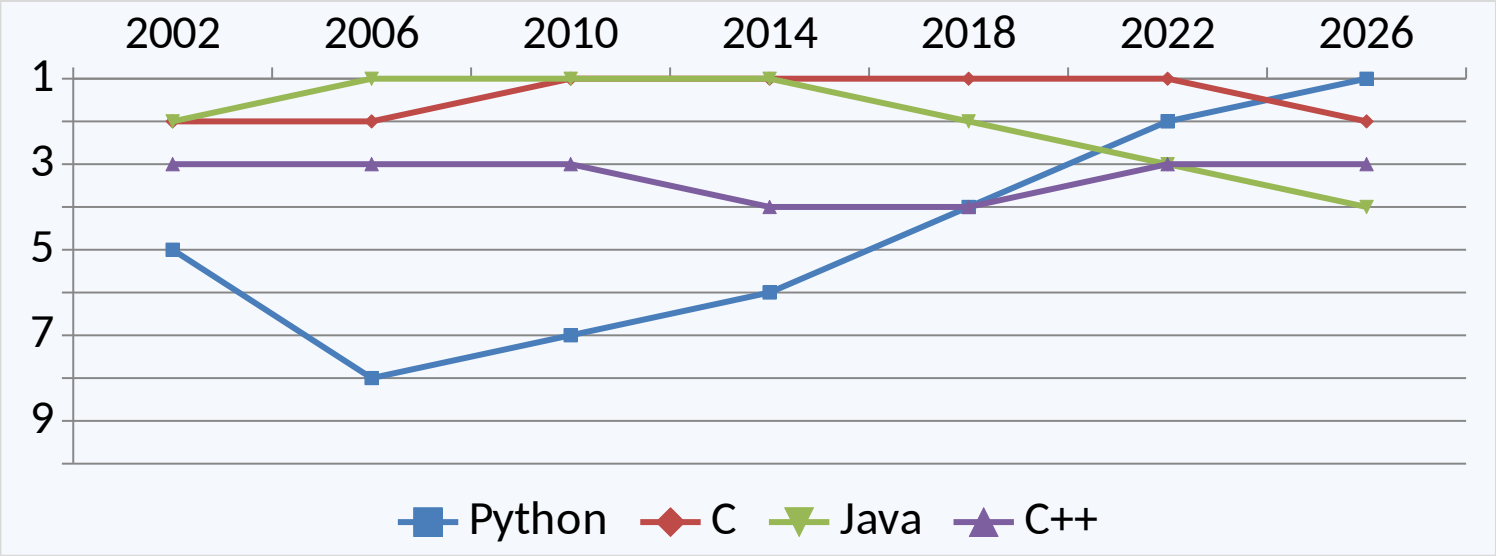
Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026



↑ Perl: 24 → 11 (+13)
↑ R: 16 → 9 (+7)
↑ Swift: 26 → 20 (+6)
↓ Go: 7 → 16 (-9)
↓ C++: 2 → 3 (-1)
↓ Java: 3 → 4 (-1)

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	1986	1991	1996	2001	2006	2011	2016	2021	2026
Python	-	-	-	26	8	7	5	3	1
C	1	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	2
Java	-	-	31	3	1	1	1	2	4
C++	9	2	2	4	3	3	3	4	3
Ada	3	10	6	18	16	22	25	36	14
Lisp	2	4	8	19	14	13	26	34	26



Python: unranked pre-1991 → #1 in 2026
C: top-2 in every snapshot
Lisp: #2 (1986) → #26 (2026)
Ada: #3 (1986) → #14 (2026)

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times -- More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner
2016	Go
2018	Python
2019	C
2020	Python
2021	Python
2022	C++
2023	C#
2024	Python
2025	C#

Python total wins: 6 (2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, 2024)

Recent momentum: C# wins in 2023 and 2025

Go won in 2016 but fell to #16 in 2026

2017 winner is not available in source data

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Python still leads at 21.25%, but its -2.59 pt decline signals possible normalization.
C's +2.02 pt gain and return to #2 suggest enduring systems and embedded demand.
Legacy rebound: Perl (+1.05), R (+0.94), and Fortran (#12) reflect specialized longevity.
Go's drop from #7 to #16 indicates stack decisions should be stress-tested against ecosystem shifts.
Top-4 concentration (48.97%) creates talent and tooling economies—but also strategic concentration

Action Checklist

- 1) Balance hiring pipelines across top 4 + strategic niche languages
- 2) Audit codebase exposure to rapidly declining ecosystems
- 3) Prioritize internal training where language momentum is strongest